

**From “Problem Student” to Contextual Learner:
Deconstructing Bias Toward Neurodivergent and CLD Learners**

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Deconstructing Bias — Reflective Paper

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This paper examines a bias I have carried into classroom practice: the tendency to interpret neurodivergent and culturally/linguistically diverse (CLD) students through a compliance-and-deficit lens. In my practicum, that bias surfaces as an automatic story: if a student is loud, impulsive, emotionally escalated, or “not listening,” they must be choosing to be disrespectful or disruptive. For this assignment, I analyze in-person classroom interactions from my elementary practicum placement during spring 2026 using time-stamped, verbatim observation records from lessons and mentor feedback conversations, alongside one course seminar discussion on linguistic justice. I label these materials as Evidence Sets E1–E4 and Journal Artifacts J1–J3.

A crosswalk to the supporting materials is provided in `artifacts/evidence_index.md`.

The specific bias under investigation is the “problem student” stereotype as it attaches to difference: difference in regulation (often read through disability and neurodivergence) and difference in language and discourse (often read through culture and linguistic background). My guiding question is: *How do my practicum observations of neurodivergent and CLD students—especially students positioned as “problematic”—challenge the assumption that disruption is a fixed trait, and what changes when adults respond relationally rather than punitively?*

In a course roundtable discussion, I named the interpretive shift I am trying to practice: in school settings we often interpret “visible frustration, noise avoidance, or emotional escalation” as “defiance rather than as evidence” of confusion, stress, and unmet instructional needs (J3). That statement serves as the through-line of this paper.

My central claim is that what gets labeled “behavior” is often communication: a contextual response to unclear expectations, cognitive overload, linguistic mismatch, or unmet regulation needs. When the conditions shift—through relationship, co-regulation, and more linguistically just participation norms—students’ engagement shifts, revealing competence and brilliance that deficit stories erase.

Autobiographical Grounding: Naming the Bias

This paper is not written from a neutral position. I am writing as a neurodivergent Dominican-American student teacher who is simultaneously learning classroom management and learning to question the interpretive habits I bring into that work. The bias I am examining is not only something I have observed in others; it is a habit of interpretation I recognize in my own instincts, and one I need to examine honestly.

Talusan (2022) describes identity-conscious practice as the ongoing work of noticing which assumptions we carry and how they shape what we see in students—not a one-time confrontation, but a repeatable discipline. That framing captures my starting point. The stereotype I am interrogating—that certain students are naturally disruptive, lazy, or unmotivated—is not one I consciously endorse; it is a reflex shaped by schooling environments in which compliance read as competence and visible struggle read as character deficit.

In an EDU 442 self-portrait earlier this term (J1), I described moving through institutions that often treat culture, language, disability, and gender variance as deficits, even when they are sources of insight and resilience. I used a puzzle metaphor to reject a fragmented view of self: Dominican heritage, first-generation class position, ADHD, chronic illness, and culturally/linguistically diverse life experience interlock rather than compete. That metaphor matters here because the “problem student” stereotype is ultimately a story about which ways of speaking, moving, and processing are treated as legitimate.

This history makes me protective of neurodivergent and CLD students. These students are not abstract to me; in many ways, they are helping me read a part of my own life that, as a child, I did not yet have language for. Yet that protectiveness does not automatically inoculate me against bias. Under time pressure or public scrutiny, it is easy to reach for control. In a journal letter to my future teacher-self (J2), I worried about systems that “say equity” but still reward compliance. This paper is an attempt to practice a different reflex: to pause, ask what a behavior is communicating, and design conditions where more students can be seen as fully human learners.

Observation Context

The evidence base for this paper comes from my elementary school practicum placement during spring 2026 and one EDU 442 seminar discussion.

Evidence Set E1 is drawn from a grade 5 media and technology lesson (March 3, 2026) in which students learned to create short GIF videos on their Chromebooks. A focal student (pseudonym *Student M*) was repeatedly framed through a behavioral deficit narrative—described as “screaming” and “yelling”—while adults alternated between public compliance demands and more relational de-escalation moves, including offering purposeful roles and negotiated incentives.

Evidence Set E2 comes from a grade 2 robotics and routines block (February 26, 2026). An adult explicitly named one student’s behavior as “ruining this for your whole class” and “doing weird stuff,” before repositioning that same student as competent and helpful: “You’re smart, you can help them.”

Evidence Set E3 is a mentor feedback conversation (April 8, 2026) in which my mentor described how relational connection and patience changed what was possible for *Student M* across the school day.

Evidence Set E4 is an EDU 442 seminar discussion on linguistic justice (March 9, 2026) in which we examined how dominant language and discourse norms shape what counts as “respect” and “participation” in schools. I draw on this discussion to explore how CLD students can be misread when schools treat silence, speed, and standardized speech as the only legitimate modes of learning.

Ethically, all student identifiers are removed. Student names in quoted excerpts are replaced with pseudonyms in square brackets. Ellipses (...) indicate omitted words; quoted phrasing otherwise preserves the original wording and disfluencies of spoken interaction. Because Evidence Sets E1–E4 are unpublished practicum and course observation materials, they are cited in-text but not included in the References list.

Myth vs. Reality: Core Analysis

The myth. Neurodivergent and CLD students become “problem students” because they are naturally disruptive, disrespectful, or unwilling to learn. This myth rests on two linked assumptions: (1) that silence and compliance equal learning, and (2) that deviation from dominant behavioral and linguistic norms signals character deficit.

DisCrit (Annamma et al., 2013) and Flynn’s (2024) affirmative non-tragedy model help name why this is not a neutral mistake: deficit framings of difference become grounds for control rather than support, and over time they shape students’ trajectories. The linguistic justice seminar (E4) revealed how the same apparatus operates for CLD students—when schools treat only one discourse style as legitimate, difference is not just misunderstood; it is disciplined.

The reality. Across my practicum observation records (E1–E3), the “problem student” category is produced moment-by-moment through adult talk, task design, and relationship—not by anything fixed in the student. In the grade 5 media lesson (E1), adults at times framed *Student M*’s body and voice as the problem to be suppressed through public compliance demands.

Yet the same record captures a different set of moves that changed what was possible. Another adult invited *Student M* into a purposeful helper role and reinforced specific success rather than shame; later, that adult reflected: “I’m actually so surprised how smart he is” (E1). The student’s competence was not newly created—it was newly *recognized* once the conditions supported regulation and re-entry.

The mentor feedback conversation makes the relational frame explicit. My mentor described how connection and patience reshaped the student’s entire school day: “He’s used to people just yelling at him all day.” Together, we named triggers and regulation needs—not willfulness—as the lens for understanding escalation (E3).

Assets and Funds of Knowledge

An asset-based reading of the same evidence reveals what the “problem student” narrative obscures. González, Moll, and Amanti (2005) argue that learners bring funds of knowledge from home and community that schools routinely fail to recognize. In my observation records, those assets surfaced when adults shifted from labeling to invitation. In E1, *Student M* became a contributor when given a purposeful role. In E2, an adult repositioned a struggling student as capable and needed: “You’re smart, you can help them.”

Evidence Set E2 also offers language that centers cognitive diversity rather than pathologizing it: “There’s never just one way to solve a problem when you’re coding. There’s always multiple ways to figure it out, and the way that you guys think differently is a strength.” This matters because it names neurodivergent ways of thinking as something worth organizing instruction around—not as deviation to be managed.

For CLD students, assets are also linguistic. In our seminar (E4), we discussed inviting students to explain ideas “in their own language” as an equity move in computer science instruction. Paris and Alim’s (2014) culturally sustaining pedagogy helps clarify why this matters: when schooling treats only one language variety and one participation style as legitimate, it erases communicative strength. hooks (1994) extends this into what she calls engaged pedagogy—staying curious about the whole person underneath the behavior and building conditions where students can participate without being erased.

Implications for Future Practice

These observations change what I want to do before I assign a label to a student. Talusan (2022) argues that identity-conscious practice is built from repeatable daily habits—not grand gestures, but routines of noticing and questioning. The following commitments are habits I intend to rehearse in real time.

Treat escalation as information, not defiance. When I notice a student yelling, shut down, or talking out of turn, my first questions should be contextual: What is the student communicating? What triggered this? What support would make participation possible in the next two minutes? This orientation aligns with Flynn’s (2024) affirmative model: difficulty is real, but the response should be support and dignity rather than control and shame.

Lead with relationship and co-regulation. In E1 and E3, purposeful roles, patience, and competence-talk supported re-entry into learning. These relational moves are not optional extras—they are instruction.

Practice linguistic justice as classroom management. When schools define “respect” primarily as silence, speed, and standardized speech, CLD and neurodivergent students are structurally set up to be misread (E4; Paris & Alim, 2014). As I wrote to my future teacher-self (J2), my concern is not structure itself—it is structure deployed to purchase adult comfort through compliance. The goal is participation norms that are explicit, humane, and designed for learning.

Across all of this, I want to audit my language and my interpretations consistently (Annamma et al., 2013; Nieto, 2004): Am I labeling a student, or describing conditions and supports? hooks (1994) keeps the ethical center in view—scaffold before shame, narrate competence before deficit, design participation structures that make room for more than one way of being a learner.

Conclusion

I began this paper with a bias that is easy to carry invisibly into classroom practice: the reflex to read behavioral and communicative difference as evidence of fixed student character. Practicum observation gave me evidence to interrupt that reflex.

Across the evidence sets, I saw how quickly a student can be produced as a “problem” through adult interpretation—and how quickly that category can loosen when adults respond relationally. When adults shifted from public control to co-regulation and competence-talk, participation became possible again (E1–E3). The linguistic justice lens sharpened the stakes for CLD students (E4): when schools treat silence, speed, and standardized speech as the only legitimate ways to learn, difference is not just misunderstood—it is disciplined.

Going forward, my commitment is to make the interpretive pause into pedagogy: to read behavior as communication, design conditions that widen participation, and use structure to support learning rather than purchase compliance. In my own words, I want it to be less likely that another CLD, neurodivergent kid slips through cracks that were never accidents (J2).

References

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